DAILY READING • 样张

The Bilge Log

2026-11-07 · 当天 50 词全部覆盖 · 全文 632 词 · 5 段

短文

The hearing opened at nine in a room that smelled of radiator dust and wet wool. Judge Halloran had been appointed to the harbour court only last spring, and she disliked long speeches. The claim concerned a cargo of superior cloth loaded on a charter vessel for commercial export. A terrorist alert at the port had closed the main gate for eleven hours that August. Because of the alert, the vessel missed the peak of the tide and waited three miles offshore. The owner sat in the front section with a lawyer and two silent clerks. Owen watched the clock above the door and wished the room had a window. The case was more complex than the file suggested, since two insurers argued over who should pay.

Owen had spent two days aboard before loading, checking every precaution the owners had listed. A small sensor in the forward hold recorded temperature every hour. The log showed a linear rise from Monday noon, with no sudden jump. Forecasters had failed to predict the heat, which held near thirty-eight for a week. The pump mechanism that should have cleared the bilge had jammed on the first night out. A temporary repair held for a day, then gave way as the water began to exceed the safe mark. Night readings took a downward turn, and the damage looked smaller than it was. He did not want to exaggerate the gravity of that failure. His answers stayed consistent with the report he had written in September.

The lawyer for the insurer was a witty man who smiled before every difficult question. He asked whether the owners had cut the maintenance budget in the spring. Owen admitted that the spare parts store had shrunk, and that scarcity was ordinary there. Nobody had informed him of the earlier failures, and he said so twice. He happened to overhear the chief engineer ask for a new pump. The company denies that the request was made, and their paperwork agrees. Counsel wanted to know the intent behind the delay. Owen kept his temper, though the questions grew sharper as the afternoon passed. The judge was tolerant of repetition but not of answers that avoided the point. Every crew member had to memorize the loading checklist.

On the third day the hold was opened, and the smell of indigo dye filled the dock. Forty drums had cracked in the heat, and the cloth beneath them had begun to decay. Beside it stood a crate of plaster saints and a box of ornaments. Owen photographed each item in the order he found it. He was thirsty by noon, since the dock water tasted of rust. That night he slept in a motel on the coast road. The crew had stayed loyal to the captain, and their loyalty shaped what they told him. He wanted to convey one plain fact, that the damage began before the ship sailed. His report was sincere, but it was also careful, because he knew who would read it.

The judge elevated her glasses and read the ruling in a flat, unhurried voice. She said the owners had perceived the risk and had done nothing about it. The damage to the cloth was permanent, and no dye could bring the colour back. Shortly before noon she ordered compensation for the buyer and costs for the hearing. She spoke of the necessity of honest logs in an era of cheap freight. The average claim there was smaller, but this one had been argued well. Owen felt compelled to stay until the room emptied, though his work was done. The ultimate cost would fall on a company that had saved a little on a pump. Outside, the tide had turned, and the gulls were loud above the empty quay.

解析 · 行间留白，可直接手写

The hearing opened at nine in a room that smelled of radiator dust and wet wool. Judge Halloran **had been appointed to** the harbour court only last spring, and she disliked long speeches. The claim concerned **a cargo of superior cloth** loaded on a charter vessel for commercial export. A terrorist alert at the port had closed the main gate for eleven hours that August. Because of the alert, the vessel **missed the peak of the tide** and waited three miles offshore. The owner sat in the front section with a lawyer and two silent clerks. Owen watched the clock above the door and wished the room had a window. The case was more complex than the file suggested, since two insurers argued over who should pay.

> **had been appointed to** 被任命到（某职位、某机构） appoint sb to a post / a committee，介词固定用 to，不用 in；名词 appointment 后也接 to，如 her appointment to the bench
> **a cargo of superior cloth** 一批上等布料 superior 本身已含比较义，没有比较级和最高级，比较时用 superior to，绝不说 superior than
> **missed the peak of the tide** 错过了潮水的最高位 peak of sth 指某物的峰值，at the peak of 表处于高峰；tide 指潮汐这一现象，high tide 才是满潮那一刻

Owen had spent two days aboard before loading, **checking every precaution** the owners had listed. A small sensor in the forward hold recorded temperature every hour. The log showed **a linear rise** from Monday noon, with no sudden jump. Forecasters had failed to predict the heat, which held near thirty-eight for a week. The pump mechanism that should have cleared the bilge had jammed on the first night out. A temporary repair held for a day, then gave way as the water began to exceed the safe mark. Night readings took a downward turn, and the damage looked smaller than it was. He did not want to **exaggerate the gravity of** that failure. His answers stayed consistent with the report he had written in September.

> **checking every precaution** 逐条核对每一项预防措施 precaution 可数，常用 take precautions against sth；every 后接单数名词，故用 precaution 不加 s
> **a linear rise** 线性上升 linear 指呈直线、成比例的，linear rise / growth 是描述数据的固定说法，与 stepwise（阶跃式）相对
> **exaggerate the gravity of** 夸大……的严重性 gravity 除“重力”外可指事态严重，常见 the gravity of the situation / the offence；exaggerate 直接接宾语，不加 about

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> **the maintenance budget** 维修预算 budget 可数，削减用 cut / trim a budget，超出用 exceed a budget；作动词时 budget for sth 表为某事编预算
> **kept his temper** 按住了性子，没有发火 keep / lose one's temper 是固定搭配，temper 前必须带物主代词；temper 作动词则是“使缓和”，如 temper the wind
> **tolerant of repetition** 对重复内容比较宽容 be tolerant of / towards sth，介词不用 to；名词 tolerance 同样接 of，如 tolerance of noise

On the third day the hold was opened, and the smell of indigo dye filled the dock. Forty drums had cracked in the heat, and the cloth beneath them **had begun to decay**. Beside it stood a crate of plaster saints and a box of ornaments. Owen photographed each item in the order he found it. He was thirsty by noon, since the dock water tasted of rust. That night he slept in a motel on the coast road. The crew had **stayed loyal to** the captain, and their loyalty shaped what they told him. He **wanted to convey** one plain fact, that the damage began before the ship sailed. His report was sincere, but it was also careful, because he knew who would read it.

> **had begun to decay** 已经开始腐烂 decay 作动词不及物，主语是被腐坏的东西，不能说 be decayed by；作名词不可数，指腐烂或衰败
> **stayed loyal to** 始终忠于（某人） be / stay / remain loyal to sb，介词固定为 to；名词 loyalty 也接 to，如 loyalty to the captain
> **wanted to convey** 想传达（某个意思） convey 的宾语是信息、意思、谢意，不能以“人”作宾语；要给对象就用 convey sth to sb

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> **ordered compensation for** 判给……赔偿金 compensation 不可数，赔偿对象用 for，如 claim / pay compensation for the loss；表示“作为……的补偿”用 in compensation for
> **in an era of cheap freight** 在运费低廉的时代 era 指有共同特征的一段时代，in an era of sth；与 age 比更强调标志性特征，与 period 比更带历史分期意味
> **felt compelled to** 觉得非……不可 feel compelled to do sth 指受情势所迫而非被外力强逼；主动结构是 compel sb to do sth，被动是 be compelled to

译文

听证会在九点开始，屋里是暖气片的灰尘味和湿羊毛的气味。哈洛伦法官去年春天才被任命到海事法庭，她不喜欢长篇陈述。这桩索赔涉及的是一批上等布料，装在一艘包租船上，用于商业出口。那年八月，港口因一起恐怖警报关闭了正门十一个小时。因为这次警报，船错过了潮水的最高点，在离岸三海里处等着。船东坐在前排，身边是一位律师和两名沉默的书记员。欧文望着门上方的钟，希望这屋子能有扇窗。这个案子比卷宗看上去更复杂，因为两家保险公司在争谁来赔。

装货前欧文在船上待了两天，把船东列出的每一条预防措施都逐项查过。前舱里一个小传感器每小时记录一次温度。日志显示从周一中午起是一条线性上升，中间没有突然的跳跃。预报员没能预告那场高温，它连着一个星期停在三十八度上下。本该抽干舱底积水的泵装置，在第一晚出航时就卡住了。一次临时修补撑了一天，随后在水位开始超过安全刻度时失效。夜里的读数出现了一个向下的转折，于是损失看上去比实际小。他不想把那次故障的严重性说得过头。他的回答与九月写的那份报告始终一致。

保险公司的律师是个机智的人，每问一个难题之前都先笑一下。他问船东是不是在春天削减了维修预算。欧文承认备件库确实缩了，而在那里缺件是常事。此前那几次故障没人通知过他，这话他说了两遍。他碰巧听到轮机长要一台新泵。公司否认有过这个请求，他们的文书也是这么写的。律师想知道拖延背后的意图。欧文按住了脾气，尽管问题随着下午过去越来越尖。法官能容忍重复，却不能容忍绕开要点的回答。每个船员都得把装货清单背下来。

第三天货舱打开，靛蓝染料的气味灌满了码头。四十只桶在高温里裂了，压在下面的布料已经开始腐烂。旁边立着一箱石膏圣徒像，还有一箱铜饰。欧文按发现的顺序给每一件拍照。到中午他就渴了，因为码头上的水一股铁锈味。那天夜里他睡在海岸公路上的一家汽车旅馆。船员一直忠于船长，而这份忠诚决定了他们对他讲了什么。他想传达一件简单的事实：损坏在船开之前就开始了。他的报告是诚挚的，但也很谨慎，因为他知道谁会读它。

法官把眼镜往上推了推，用平板而不急的语调宣读裁决。她说船东已经察觉到了风险，却什么也没做。布料的损坏是永久的，没有哪种染料能把颜色带回来。临近中午，她判给买方赔偿金，并判付本次听证的费用。她谈到在一个运费低廉的时代里，诚实的日志有多必要。那个法庭上平均的索赔额要小些，但这一桩辩得很扎实。欧文觉得非留下来不可，直到屋里的人都走空，尽管他的活已经干完。最终的成本会落到一家在一台泵上省了点钱的公司头上。外面潮水已经转了，海鸥在空码头上叫得很响。